

Stephen Ta
Professor Stillman
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Maya Angelou: The Pen That Defeated a Century of Prejudice

To be honest, when I first read Maya Angelou's poetry, I didn't like it. Perhaps, because her works use rhythms and structures that are different from the poetic traditions I grew up with, they seem hard to resonate with on a first read. However, as time passed, my appreciation for her work grew greatly. I realised what her work is truly about. They are meant to be felt, heard, and experienced. Rooted deeply in the African American spirituals and blues traditions, her work uses the rhythm of spoken performance to navigate the hardships of unfair treatment, carrying a message of survival. To fully appreciate her work, one must bring themselves back to the 1970s Black Feminist movement. In 1977, the Combahee River Collective published a famous statement defining a philosophy that recognized the links between race, class, and sex unfairness ("Still I Rise: Historical"). Published just a year later in 1978, Angelou's collection *And Still I Rise* is divided into three chronological parts, which function as a poetic perfect example of this philosophy, insisting on the value and freedom of Black women. Through formal techniques, Angelou composes a universal anthem of empowerment for Black women.

The theme of body pride and self-acceptance is proudly realized in Part One of the book, "Touch Me, Life, Not Softly," especially in poems like "Phenomenal Woman". In "Phenomenal Woman," Angelou weakened traditional, Europe-focused standards of beauty, insisting that a Black woman's power and charm stem from her confidence, inner strength, and physical presence (Shrestha 46). The poem utilizes very short lines within long stanzas to make each line stand out, creating an emphatic rhythm. Its simple diction and conversational tone give the speaker a direct, unapologetic voice. Furthermore, the repetition of the word "phenomenal" emphasizes self-assertion (Shrestha 47). With limited metaphor density, the poem focuses instead on concrete physical confidence, like the arch of her back, her smile,

and her heels (Angelou). The imagery of men swarming like honeybees to a hive makes the speaker the central "sweet" figure (Shrestha 46). This pride is equally clear in later poems like "Still I Rise," where the speaker boldly asks, "Does my sexiness upset you?" and rejoices in the "diamonds at the meeting of my thighs" (Angelou). Angelou also fights societal attempts to look down on the Black female body. The oppressor demands a "broken" figure with "bowed head and lowered eyes," visually breaking down the woman into parts (Angelou). However, Angelou naturally binds the speaker's identity back together, proving her spirit remains whole despite hostile outside forces. Through this blending of form and meaning, the Black female body is transformed from a site of historical trauma into an unbeatable source of gold mines and oil wells ("Still I Rise: Structure").

Moving into Part Two of the collection, "Traveling," the poems shift to explore movement, freedom, and various societal roles. A standout example is "Lady Luncheon Club," which explores the comfortable distance of privileged audiences from real-world struggles. The poem uses short lines and a conversational, humorous tone to describe a woman politely distancing herself from the "grave social horrors" discussed by an overly intellectual male speaker ("Lady Luncheon Club"). Instead of engaging with the serious public discourse, the women are distracted by whether the cake is too sweet or the coffee is too strong ("Lady Luncheon Club"). Like other poems in this section, such as "California Prodigal," Angelou uses movement and observation to examine the conditions of the world around her, capturing the gap between lived realities and polite society.

In Part Three of the collection, "And Still I Rise," Angelou's speaker is a Black woman who wants to show her strength in the face of an unfair, racist society. She builds this theme of resistance in poems like "Ain't That Bad?" and the title piece, "Still I Rise". To build this tone of joyful boldness, Angelou relies heavily on structural choices. The poem's underlying rhythm is most clear when the speaker asks: "Does my sassiness upset you? / Why are you beset with gloom? / 'Cause I walk like I've got oil wells / Pumping in my living room" (Angelou). As this stanza shows, Angelou changes the rhythm by dropping syllables at the ends of lines to force a natural pause. This missing syllable creates a forward push, giving the reader the feeling of the speaker's confident, strutting walk. Furthermore, Angelou

breaks this pattern to highlight moments of resistance. In the opening stanza, the meter suddenly shifts in a shorter line: "But still, like dust, I'll rise" (Angelou). The use of the simile comparing the speaker to dust is deeply symbolic. On a surface level, dust floats upward when stomped on, mirroring the speaker's refusal to be crushed. However, dust is also an annoyance. By rising, the speaker actively interrupts and bothers the very unfair systems trying to hold her down. Additionally, the simile of "like dust" hints at the Biblical making of humanity from the earth in Genesis, framing the speaker's rise as a taking back of the very first human story.

As "Still I Rise" progresses, Angelou uses enjambment and anaphora to speed up the poem's emotional power. The sequence of rhetorical questions like "You may shoot me...", "You may cut me...", "You may kill me..." highlights the nature of official and personal violence (Angelou). Angelou suggests that violence is not always physical. Historical and verbal wiping out, carried out through "bitter, twisted lies," functions as a severe form of control (Angelou). In this sense, the oppressor's emotions and words are used as weapons, turning hatred and lies into sharp, harmful tools. To fight this attack, the poem's rhythm breaks free from its initial limits. In the later stanzas, Angelou shifts into a new rhythm: "Out of the huts of history's shame / I rise / Up from a past that's rooted in pain / I rise" (Angelou). This shift reflects a growing sense of self, further highlighted by the repeating, separate refrain, "I rise". Here, the speaker linked herself to an ocean: "I'm a black ocean, leaping and wide, / Welling and swelling I bear in the tide" (Angelou). The ocean metaphor operates on multiple levels. Historically, it calls up the Middle Passage and the trauma of the transatlantic slave trade. Personally and collectively, however, it is a symbol of feminine reproduction and birth, capturing a tide that is "welling and swelling" to bring forth a new, free reality. The syncopated rhythm, short lines, and repetition of "I rise" act as accessible tools that reinforce the theme of resistance against oppression, showing the speaker's unstoppable forward push.

When read collectively, "Phenomenal Woman," "Lady Luncheon Club," "Ain't That Bad?", and "Still I Rise" reveal the core of Angelou's poetic project: to go against unfair social expectations and take back history. The three sections of the book track a chronological journey from physical self-acceptance to standing up against societal oppression. Angelou's speakers refuse to remain tied to "a past that's rooted

in pain". Her poetry performs an important action, challenging stories and recovering cultural and political space for those who have been historically silenced. Ultimately, Maya Angelou's poetry matters because it masterfully translates the specific, historical traumas of the pushed aside into universal declarations of hope. Through her accessible techniques, she ensures that no matter how bitter the history, the song of freedom will always rise.

Work cited

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